

- RAG Learning

1.4 Voting Behaviour and the Media

Politics — Edexcel (9PL0) — Component 1: UK Politics, Section A

This topic closes Section A of Component 1. The spec requires **three general election case studies** — one from 1945–92, the 1997 election, and one since 1997 — plus the influence of the media. The case studies are compulsory content, so knowing three elections in real detail is not optional. Choose them to make *different* analytical points.

Class dealignment — the weakening of the link between social class and party support.

Partisan dealignment — the weakening of voters' habitual attachment to a party.

Valence — judgement of a party's competence to deliver commonly held goals, as opposed to disagreement about what the goals should be.

Governing competency — the electorate's assessment of how capably a government has performed.

Disillusion and apathy — withdrawal from politics through loss of faith, or through indifference.

Manifesto — the statement of pledges a party offers the electorate.

Mandate — the authority a winning party claims to enact that programme.

Swing — the average shift in support from one party to another between elections.

Rational choice — voting as a calculation of self-interest rather than as an expression of loyalty.

1. Models of voting behaviour

Model	Claim	Strength / weakness
Structural (sociological)	Vote follows social position — class, region, ethnicity, tenure	Explained the 1945–70 period well; weakened sharply thereafter

Party identification	Voters develop a standing loyalty, often inherited, that persists across elections	Explains stability; cannot explain the volatility since 1974
Rational choice	Voters weigh policies and likely performance and vote in their own interest	Fits a dealigned electorate; assumes information and effort many voters do not invest
Valence	Voters judge competence to deliver shared goals rather than choosing between goals	The dominant contemporary account; explains why economic reputation tracks electoral fortune
Dominant ideology	Preferences are shaped by media and elite framing rather than formed independently	Explains agenda effects; hard to test, and risks treating voters as passive

Long-term (structural) factors

Factor	Historic pattern	Position now
Social class	In 1964 around two-thirds voted for their "natural" class party	Substantially weakened by occupational change, affluence, home ownership and educational expansion
Age	A modest effect	Now among the strongest divides; the crossover point has been estimated at around 50
Education	Weak	A major divide since 2016, correlating with socially liberal attitudes and with the Brexit vote
Region	North/South and urban/rural	Persistent and sharpened: Scotland is effectively a separate party system
Ethnicity	Strong Labour lean among minority ethnic voters	Still present but weakening, and varying considerably between groups

Housing tenure	Owner-occupiers lean Conservative	Strongly predictive, and interacts with age
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Short-term factors

- **Governing competency** — the dominant valence consideration; economic reputation tracks electoral fortune closely.
- **Party leaders** — perceptions of competence, trustworthiness and prime ministerial credibility; more consequential as partisan attachment has weakened.
- **Party unity** — visible division signals inability to govern.
- **Manifesto and specific policies** — occasionally decisive, as with the 2017 social care proposal, which was withdrawn mid-campaign.
- **Campaign and media** — agenda-setting determines the ground the contest is fought on.
- **Tactical voting** — a rational response to FPTP, and a persistent distortion of stated preference.

2. Case study: 1979

Result	Conservative 339 seats, 43.9%; Labour 269, 36.9%. Majority of 43. Turnout 76.0%
Context	The Winter of Discontent — widespread public sector strikes through 1978–79; high inflation; the IMF loan of 1976; the collapse of the Lib–Lab pact and a lost confidence vote by one
Why it mattered	Ended the post-war consensus. Thatcher's programme — trade union reform, privatisation, monetarism, right-to-buy — broke with the settlement both parties had accepted since 1945
Voting behaviour	A significant swing among skilled working-class (C2) voters to the Conservatives — early and clear evidence of class dealignment. Right-to-buy subsequently consolidated it by converting tenants into owner-occupiers

Media	The Saatchi "Labour Isn't Working" poster is the standard illustration of agenda-setting: it made unemployment the frame despite the Conservatives having no immediate remedy
Use it for	Class dealignment; the end of consensus; short-term events (the strikes) overriding long-term loyalty

3. Case study: 1997

Result	Labour 418 seats, 43.2%; Conservative 165, 30.7%. Majority of 179 — the largest since 1935. Turnout 71.4%
Context	Eighteen years of Conservative government; the ERM crisis of September 1992 had destroyed the party's reputation for economic management; sustained and visible division over Europe; a run of scandals
Why it mattered	New Labour had abandoned the positions of 1983 and rewritten Clause IV in 1995, so the contest turned on competence rather than on ideological disagreement — the clearest case of valence voting in modern British politics
Voting behaviour	Labour's gains were largest among middle-class and southern voters — groups the class model would not have predicted. Its vote became markedly less class-distinctive
The competence point	Conservative polling on economic competence never recovered after 1992, despite a growing economy by 1997. Reputations lost through visible failure do not recover quickly — the same pattern recurred after 2022
Caution	A landslide in seats rested on 43.2% of the vote, so FPTP exaggerated the scale of the shift in opinion
Use it for	Valence voting; governing competence; convergence; the distorting effect of FPTP

4. Case study: 2019

Result	Conservative 365 seats, 43.6%; Labour 202, 32.1%. Majority of 80. Turnout 67.3%
Context	Three years of parliamentary deadlock after the 2016 referendum; a minority government; the Brexit Party threatening the Conservative flank
Why it mattered	Realignment rather than swing. Leave-voting Labour seats across the Midlands and North — the "red wall" — moved Conservative, many for the first time in their history
Voting behaviour	Brexit cut across the class alignment. Education and the 2016 vote predicted party choice better than occupation; age remained a powerful divide
Leadership	Leader ratings diverged sharply, and in a dealigned electorate that carried more weight than it would have in 1964
The counterpoint	A coalition assembled on one issue is vulnerable once that issue recedes — which the 2024 result went on to demonstrate, with large swings in the opposite direction within five years
Use it for	Realignment; new cleavages; the limits of long-term models; volatility

Exam Tip: Using three elections to make the same point wastes two of them. 1979 for class dealignment and the end of consensus; 1997 for valence and competence; 2019 for realignment along a new cleavage. If a question asks about the importance of a single factor, select the election that tests it hardest rather than the one you know best.

5. The influence of the media

Theories of media effect

Theory	Claim	Evidence
Reinforcement	The media mainly confirm existing preferences, because readers choose outlets that already agree with them	Readership correlates with prior party support; conversion effects are hard to find
Agenda-setting	The media shape which issues are treated as important, and so the ground the contest is fought on	Immigration salience rose sharply alongside coverage before 2016
Direct effects	Coverage converts voters	Weakly supported; <i>The Sun's</i> 1992 claim is the standard example, and is widely doubted
Reverse causation	Proprietors back the likely winner, so endorsements follow a shift already underway	<i>The Sun</i> switched to Labour in 1997 when Labour's lead was already large

Broadcasters, press and social media

- **Broadcasters** are bound by statutory **due impartiality** requirements under the Communications Act 2003 and the Ofcom code, which constrains partisan influence in the medium most people rely on for news. Televised leaders' debates, first held in 2010, have personalised campaigns further.
- **The press** is openly partisan and faces no impartiality duty, but circulation has fallen sharply, which limits reach. Ownership is concentrated, which is a separate concern from partisanship.
- **Social media** differs in kind: targeting and algorithmic curation mean voters may see different messages, weakening the shared public account of a campaign. Spending is harder to regulate and provenance harder to verify. The Cambridge Analytica controversy prompted the Elections Act 2022 requirement for digital imprints identifying who paid for political material.

Opinion polls

Polls have misfired repeatedly — 1992, 2015 and 2017 — principally through sampling error and turnout modelling. The British Polling Council inquiry after 2015 identified unrepresentative samples as the main cause. Their political effect is contested: they may encourage tactical voting,

depress turnout where a result looks certain, or produce a bandwagon effect. They are not banned during UK campaigns, unlike in France and some other democracies.

Exam Tip: On media influence, the strongest judgement is that influence and reflection run together and cannot be cleanly separated: coverage shapes salience and reinforces existing leanings, while proprietors also back likely winners. An answer asserting either "the media decide elections" or "the media have no effect" is weaker than one explaining why the question is hard to settle empirically.

6. Explaining the decline of long-term models

Class and partisan dealignment left far more voters unanchored and willing to switch, so short-term factors do more of the work than they did in the 1960s. Volatility between elections is markedly higher — 2019 and 2024 produced large swings in opposite directions within five years, which no stable long-term model predicts.

But the more precise account is that long-term factors have not stopped mattering; the *relevant* factors have changed. Age, education and housing tenure are stable, slow-moving attributes that now predict party support at least as strongly as occupational class once did. The real change is that these divides cut **across** the party system rather than aligning neatly with it, which makes them less useful for predicting which party a voter will support even where they still predict what a voter believes. Abandoning structural explanation altogether confuses the decline of one cleavage with the decline of cleavage as such.

Quick recall

- Models: structural, party identification, rational choice, valence, dominant ideology
- Long-term: class (weakened), age, education, region, ethnicity, housing tenure
- Short-term: competence, leaders, unity, policies, campaign, tactical voting
- 1979 — Winter of Discontent; C2 swing; end of the post-war consensus; turnout 76.0%
- 1997 — majority of 179 (177 on the stricter count that treats the Speaker as Labour — both figures are in circulation) on 43.2%; valence over ideology; ERM 1992 destroyed Conservative

economic reputation

- 2019 — realignment along Brexit; red wall; a one-issue coalition, reversed by 2024
- Media: reinforcement and agenda-setting are better supported than direct conversion; proprietors back likely winners
- Broadcasters bound by due impartiality (Communications Act 2003); digital imprints required from the Elections Act 2022
- Judgement: structure still matters, but the structure now cuts across the party system